

Nielsen Norman Group

Heuristic Evaluation

Workbook

Use this workbook to conduct your own heuristic evaluation.

For each of Jakob's 10 Usability Heuristics, look for specific places where the interface fails to adhere to the guideline. Write your recommendations for how to fix those usability issues.

<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/>

Nielsen Norman Group

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Product: InternX -A microinternship platform

Task:

Browse available projects, apply for a project, track application status, manage an active project, and facilitate communication between students and businesses

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1

Visibility of System Status

The design should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within a reasonable amount of time.

- Does the design clearly communicate its state?
- Is feedback presented quickly after user actions?

Issues

The interface provides limited visual feedback for certain interactions:

- Notification (bell) icon does not provide any feedback when clicked
- File upload action lacks progress indication or confirmation

Recommendations

Introduce simple visual cues such as color changes, highlight states, or short messages:

- Display 'No notifications available' when the bell icon is clicked
- Add loading indicators/progress bar and success confirmation messages for transitions

2

Match Between System and the Real World

The design should speak the users' language. Use words, phrases, and concepts familiar to the user, rather than internal jargon. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.

- Will user be familiar with the terminology used in the design?
- Do the design's controls follow real-world conventions?

Issues

No major issues. One minor issue identified:

Terms like 'InternX Associate' and tier labels (Scholar, Associate, Professional) may not be immediately understandable to new users

Recommendations

Some tooltips or short descriptions can be added to explain platform-specific terminology

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● User Control and Freedom

Users often perform actions by mistake. They need a clearly marked "emergency exit" to leave the unwanted action without having to go through an extended process.

- Does the design allow users to go back a step in the process?
- Are exit links easily discoverable?
- Can users easily cancel an action? Is
- *Undo* and *Redo* supported?

Issues

- After clicking 'View Progression' from the Dashboard, there is no back arrow to return; the user must rely on the top navigation
- No confirmation dialog before submitting a project application; accidental submissions cannot be undone

Recommendations

- Add a back arrow button on the Progression page for direct navigation
- Add a confirmation dialog ('Are you sure you want to apply?') before finalizing an application

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Consistency and Standards

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing. Follow platform and industry conventions.

- Does the design follow industry conventions?
- Are visual treatments used consistently throughout the design?

Issues

The 'Browse Projects' button is styled as a filled (primary) button, while 'View Progression' is shown as an outlined (secondary) button. Since both actions provide important functionality, this difference in styling may create an unintended visual hierarchy

Recommendations

Maintain consistent button styling for actions of similar importance to avoid confusion

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Error Prevention

Good error messages are important, but the best designs carefully prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Either eliminate error-prone conditions, or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.

- Does the design prevent slips by using helpful constraints?
- Does the design warn users before they perform risky actions?

Issues

The 'Submit for Review' button on the Deliverables screen has no confirmation step; a user could accidentally submit incomplete or wrong work with a single click, with no warning or preview before the action is committed

Recommendations

- Add a confirmation dialog summarizing what is being submitted (file name, notes preview) before the final submission goes through
- The Submission Notes field should have a character limit indicator so that a user cannot submit overly long or empty notes without any warning

6

Recognition Rather Than Recall

Minimize the user's memory load by making elements, actions, and options visible. The user should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. Information required to use the design (e.g. field labels or menu items) should be visible or easily retrievable when needed.

- Does the design keep important information visible, so that users do not have to memorize it?
- Does the design offer help in-context?

Issues

No issues found. The design handles Recognition Rather Than Recall well. All relevant information is visible where needed:

- Percentage shown on Active Project page
- Skills highlighted on Profile page
- Budget shown under each project name in My Applications

Recommendations

No changes required

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Flexibility and Efficiency of Use

Shortcuts — hidden from novice users — may speed up the interaction for the expert user such that the design can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users. Allow users to tailor frequent actions.

- Does the design provide accelerators like keyboard shortcuts and touch gestures?
- Is content and functionality personalized or customized for individual users?

Issues

- No keyboard shortcuts are available for common actions (e.g., navigating between sections, opening search)
- No way to save or bookmark a project for later without applying, forcing users to remember projects of interest manually

Recommendations

- Implement keyboard shortcuts (e.g., Ctrl+K for search, number keys for navigation) for power users
- Add a 'Save for later' or bookmark button on project cards so users can create a shortlist without applying

8

Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

Interfaces should not contain information that is irrelevant or rarely needed. Every extra unit of information in an interface competes with the relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.

- Is the visual design and content focused on the essentials?
- Have all distracting, unnecessary elements been removed?

Issues

No major issues found. However, some sections may feel slightly dense due to multiple options in the dashboard

Recommendations

Improve spacing between sections for better readability. Less-critical stats (Total Earnings, Pending Tasks) can be moved to a collapsible or secondary panel

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Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no error codes), precisely indicate the problem, and constructively suggest a solution.

- Does the design use traditional error message visuals, like bold, red text?
- Does the design offer a solution that solves the error immediately?

Issues

The interface does not clearly differentiate between system errors and empty states in certain cases (e.g., no notifications or no search results versus a feature failure), which may make it difficult for users to understand what has occurred

Recommendations

- Display clear, plain-language error/status messages such as 'No notifications yet' for the bell icon and 'No results found for [search term]' for search
- Use color cues: red for failures, green for success confirmations

10 Help and

Documentation

It's best if the system doesn't need any additional explanation.

However, it may be necessary to provide documentation to help users understand how to complete their tasks.

- Is help documentation easy to search?
- Is help provided in context right at the moment when the user requires it?

Issues

There is no onboarding tutorial or FAQ for new users to understand the InternX platform mechanism and project workflow. While some guidance exists indirectly in the Active Project section, it is not sufficient for first-time users

Recommendations

- Add a brief onboarding walkthrough for first-time users covering tier levels and how applications work
- Include a searchable FAQ and tooltips where needed so users can find guidance at any point, not just during onboarding